
CGM

CHILTERN GARDEN MAINTENANCE

PREMIUM GARDEN GUIDE

Gardener Skills Guide

Practical skills every gardener needs

Price: £9.99 - £14.99

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Introduction

A practical guide to the core skills every gardener needs: pruning, planting, soil preparation, tool maintenance, composting, propagation, and pest/disease identification. Written for Chilterns conditions but applicable anywhere in southern England.

Pruning basics

Rule 1: always prune to an outward-facing bud. Rule 2: never remove more than 1/3 of a plant in one year. Rule 3: sharpen your secateurs before every session. Rule 4: prune spring-flowering shrubs after flowering, summer-flowering shrubs in late winter.

Soil preparation

Double-dig new beds to 45cm depth, incorporating 5cm of compost. For existing beds, mulch annually with 5cm of compost in March. Never work clay soil when wet - it destroys structure. Test pH every 3 years. Add lime to raise pH, sulphur to lower it.

Tool maintenance

Clean tools after every use. Sharpen secateurs and loppers monthly with a diamond file. Oil moving parts with WD-40. Store in a dry shed. Replace wooden handles when they split. A sharp tool is safer and faster than a blunt one.

Composting

Use a 50:50 mix of green (grass, vegetable peelings) and brown (cardboard, twigs, autumn leaves) materials. Turn every 6 weeks. Compost is ready when it is dark, crumbly, and smells of earth - usually 6-12 months. Never compost meat, dairy, or diseased plants.

About CGM

Chiltern Garden Maintenance (CGM) operates across Oxfordshire, Buckinghamshire, Berkshire and Bedfordshire. We deliver garden clearance, regular maintenance, lawn recovery, hedge cutting, fencing, soft landscaping, pressure washing, garden design and garden analysis reports. Visit chilterngardenmaintenance.com for more.